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# Social Stratification

- Meaning, Forms & Functions

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# Introduction

- All people have some differences - biological or social
- Biological differences - Age, Sex, Race
- Social Differences - Wealth, Life Style, Power etc.
- Hence, Differentiation is a a Universal Phenomenon

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# Introduction

- But, when these biological or social differences are **Socially Evaluated** in terms of superiority or inferiority, **Social Inequality** results!
- Thus, Social Inequality is a **Socially Created Inequality** based on biological or social differences naturally existing between people

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# Introduction

- Social Inequality - TWO TYPES
  - It can exist without creation of hierarchy - **Social Differentiation**
    - In almost all the societies, men & women are treated unequally, without any hierarchical ranking of men over women...
  - It can exist in the form of hierarchy -

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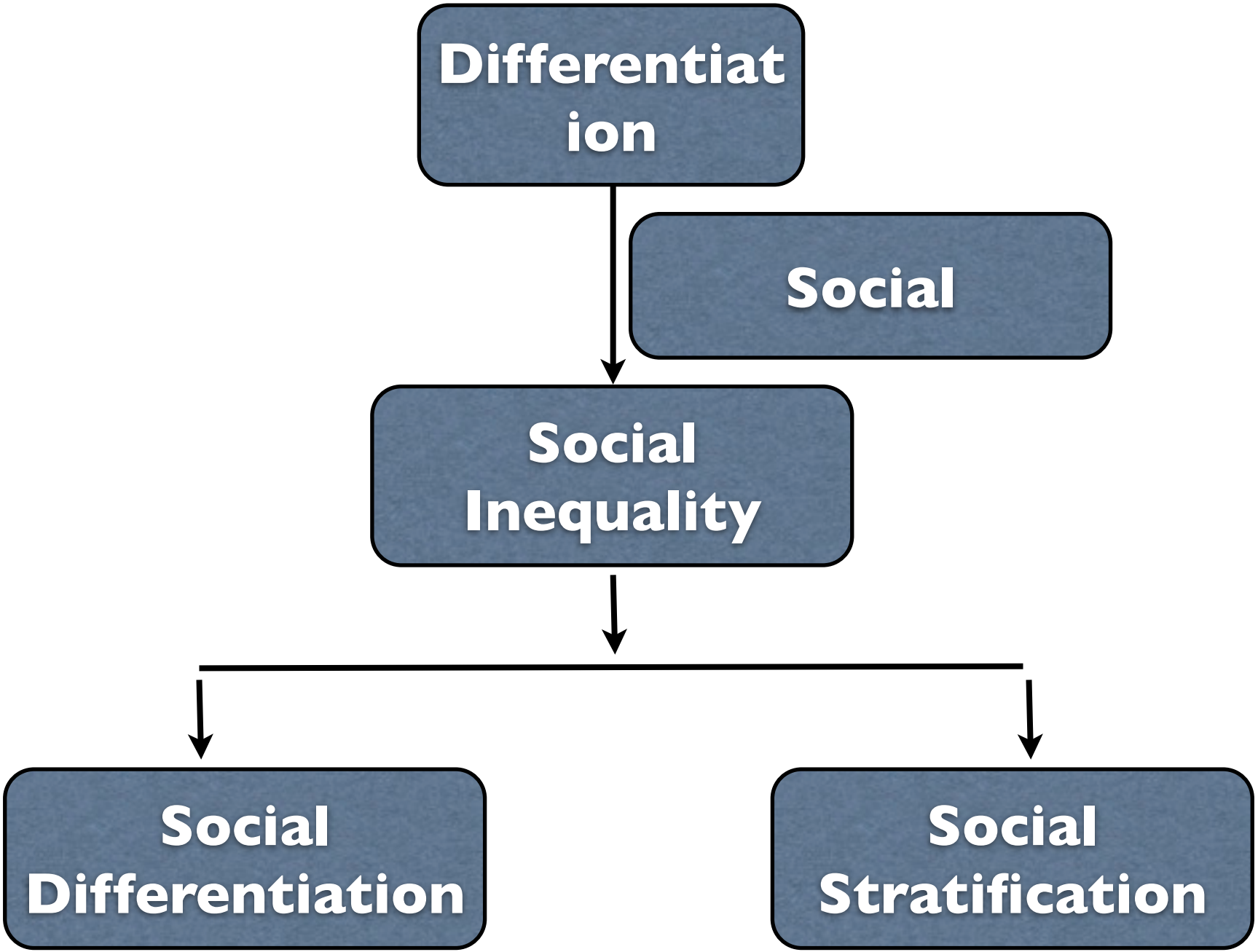
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# Introduction

- Social Hierarchy - Involves ranking of people ONE OVER THE OTHER
- Social Hierarchy is also called **Social Stratification**
- Thus, **Social Stratification is a a TYPE OF Social Inequality**

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# Meaning of Social Stratification

- The division of population into strata i.e., layers, one above the other, on the basis of possession of certain characteristics which the society regards as desirable or less desirable
  - Within this hierarchy, people have either high, intermediate or low ranks
  - Social stratification is also a **universal phenomenon**
- Sorokin – ***"Unstratified society, with a real equality of its members, is a myth which has never been realized in the history of mankind"***

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# Process

1. Differentiation of members based on certain values



2. Ranking of individuals on the basis of these values



3. Differential distribution of rewards



4. Differentiation of Prestige and Esteem

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# Criteria

- Criteria for Stratification depend on **values of the society**
- Most common ones are...
    - Birth
    - Wealth
    - Power
    - Occupation
    - Education

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# Criteria

- **Birth**
  - Ascribed qualities
  - Results in rigid structures
  - Hinders social mobility
- **Wealth**
  - Birth was a criterion only till economic development
  - Agriculture – Feudal Lords / Serfs
  - Industrialization – Bourgeoisie / Proletariat

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# Criteria

- **Occupation**
  - Closely linked to wealth
  - Feature of **modern societies**
  - Farmer – owner farmer Vs tenant farmer
  - Blue Collar Vs White Collar

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# Criteria

- **What determines the prestige of an occupation?**

1. Functional importance of the occupation
2. Scarcity of personnel
3. Degree of talent required

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# Criteria

- **Power**
  - Rulers and Ruled
  - Even in a democracy this criterion operates !!!
- **Education**
  - Good education - greater prestige - greater opportunities in life

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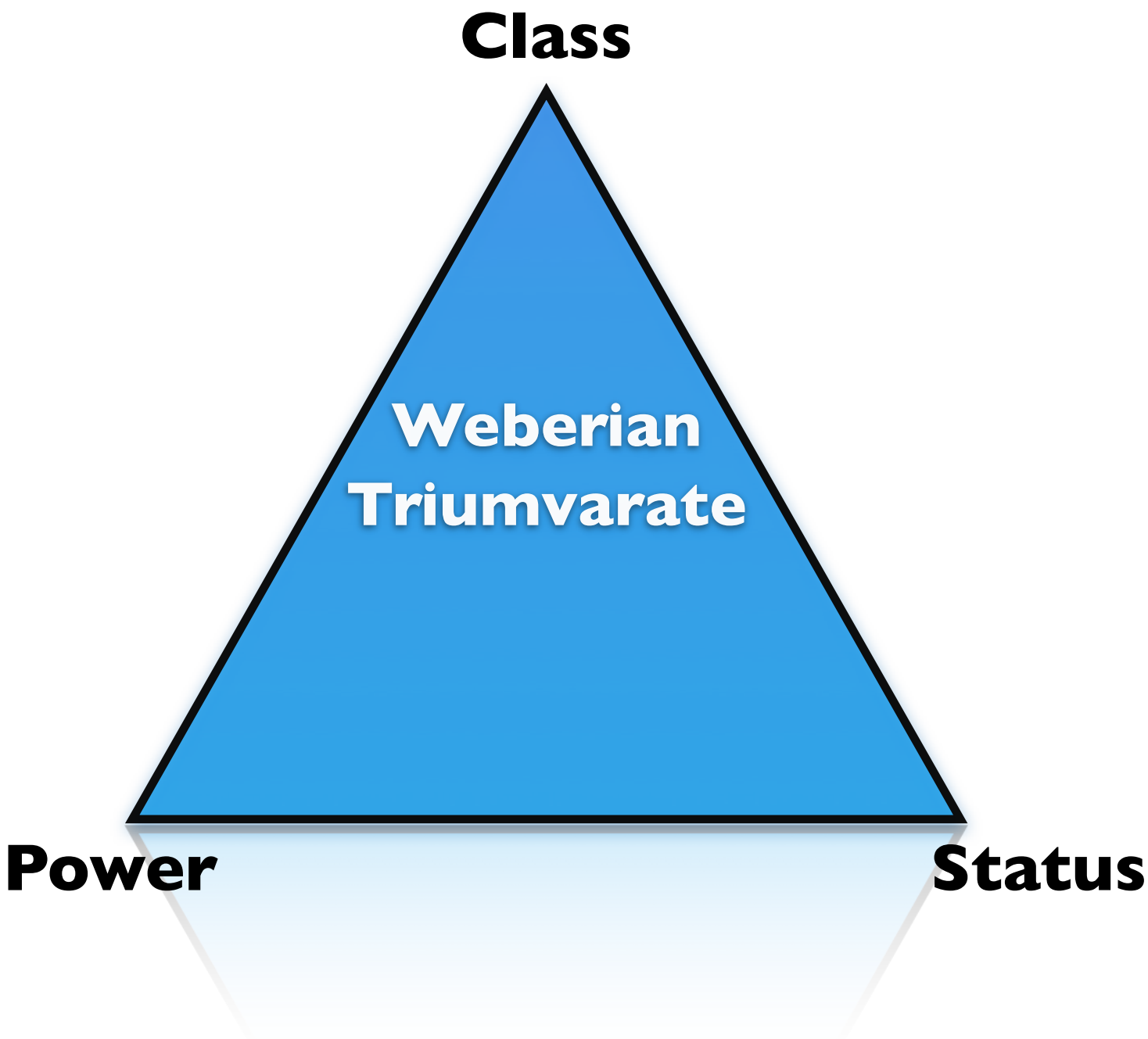
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# Dimensions of Stratification

- The search for adequate framework to explain and analyze the systems of stratification has led many sociologists to accept the notion that …
  - **Societies are stratified in the three separate dimensions of CLASS, STATUS and POWER**
- **The Weberian Triumvarate**

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# Dimensions of Stratification

- These are three dimensions of Social Stratification
  - Economic inequalities because of market position of the individual - Class
  - Differences in the life styles of people, social esteem prestige - Status
  - Inequalities in power, access to power - Power
- **This is considered the Fundamental Classification of Social Stratification under which all other types are subsumed**
- **They can overlap and need not... Ex. Negros in USA**

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# Forms of Stratification

- Social stratification is based on a variety of interpreting principles
- Hence there may be different types of stratifications
- These forms emerge due to relative weight which a society gives to characteristics like
  - Inborn qualities
  - Material possessions
  - Rigidity of strata etc.
- The principles forms are CASTE, ESTATE & CLASS

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# Caste System

- An endogamous group
- Bearing a common name
- Membership of which is hereditary
- Imposing restrictions on social intercourse on its members
- Following a common traditional occupation
- Claiming a common origin
- Forming a homogenous group

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# Features of Caste System

## 1. Segmental Division of Society

- Society – divided into castes
- Membership is by virtue of birth alone
- Status depends upon traditional importance of caste
- Each caste forming a quasi-sovereign body
- Marked off from one another

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# Features of Caste System

## 2. Social and Religious Hiearchy

- A definite scheme of social precedence
- Society divided into different strata
- Brahmin – Apex / Sudra – Low position

## 3. Endogamy

- Essence of caste system
- Only exception is Hypergamy

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# Features of Caste System

## 4. Restriction on Social Intercourse

- Complex taboos govern caste system
- Concept of **purity and pollution** – places several restrictions on systems of interaction
- Restrictions on feeding, use of public places, civic amenities etc.
- This leads to civil and religious disabilities

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# Features of Caste System

## 5. Restricted Choice of Occupations

- Members – expected to follow caste occupations
- Ideally – one cannot change the occupation
- Occupations are hereditary – a RIGHT / PRIVILEGE / DUTY

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# Estate System

- This types of social system – restricted to Medieval Europe
- Gave great deal of emphasis to birth (as in caste) and also to wealth
- The estates, unlike castes, were **legally defined**
- Each estate had a status – i.e., a legal complex of rights and duties

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# Estate System

- Pre-revolutionary Russia
  - Clergy
  - Nobility
  - Merchants
  - Peasants
- Medieval Europe - Clergy, Aristocracy & Commoners

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# Caste and Estate

1. Ritual Vs Legal definition
2. Enforcements in caste are through karma or divine sanctions and other informal means of social control while in estates it is through military strength or courts of law
3. In estates – rights and duties extends throughout the system whereas in castes – "Outcaste" substratum exists
4. Both have restrictions on social mobility – barriers in caste are ritual while in estates they are legal or man-made

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# Class System

- Class stratification – dominates in the modern world
- In such system, there are no legal distinctions between classes and hence all are subjected to same laws and all have equal citizen's rights
- A person's position is NOT determined by birth and depends to a great extent on **achievement**
- The barriers to mobility are only of **opportunity**
- Mostly found in **industrial societies**

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# Factors determining Class

1. Property
2. Income
3. Occupation and status associations
4. Power

- However, possession of any ONE of these criteria does not necessarily lead to higher ranking
- If a person possesses several factors, he is usually accepted as a member of social class

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# Three Class Sentiments

1. Feeling of equality with one's class members
2. Feeling of inferiority to those above
3. Feeling of superiority to those below

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# Caste & Class

1. Caste is inherited; Class is achieved
2. Caste is a static system and class is dynamic
3. Caste – endogamous – class – not necessary
4. Caste occupations – traditional, while class occupations are optional
5. Caste is non-secular while class is secular
6. Caste imposes social restrictions, class not

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# Functions of Stratification

1. Motivation
2. Competition
3. Reinforcing Attitudes and increasing conformity
4. Socialization
5. Social Control (-ve reference group behavior)

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# Social Mobility

- Movement of individuals along or across different levels of social stratification
- **TYPES**
  - **Horizontal & Vertical**
    - Horizontal – change in occupational position without change in social hierarchy – Ex. Rural laborer – Industrial laborer
    - Vertical – Change in position in hierarchy – Industrial laborer – businessman

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# Social Mobility

- Vertical – Two Types – Upward and Downward
- **Intergenerational & Intra Generational Mobility**

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# Consequences

1. Dis-associative to Social Stratification
2. Reinforces Class System
3. More effective use of ability
4. Malady of infinite aspiration

**Open Vs Closed Systems**

Norms prescribe / proscribe stratification

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